PROBLEM STATEMENT 26262

Detailed Understanding and Analysis of the AICTE Approval Workflow Automation and Compliance Monitoring System

Project detail	Description
Organisation	All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE)
Department	Regulation Bureau
Category	Software
Theme	Smart Automation

Purpose of this document

This document explains the problem statement in plain language, identifies the operational challenges it addresses, breaks down the required system capabilities, and summarises the expected outcomes and safeguards. It is intended as a requirements-understanding document before solution design or implementation.

Important note: Examples in this document are illustrative. Actual workflow stages, timelines, document requirements and authorised actions must be validated against the applicable AICTE regulations and Approval Process Handbook (APH).

1. Executive Summary

The All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE) processes applications from technical institutions through a series of prescribed regulatory and administrative stages. Depending on the applicable Approval Process Handbook (APH), an application may need to undergo scrutiny, re-scrutiny, an Expert Visit Committee (EVC) process, SAC/SHC review, or other prescribed procedures.

In addition to processing applications, AICTE must monitor conditions attached to approvals, time-bound institutional undertakings, compliance submissions and the validity of prescribed documents, including lease documents where applicable.

These activities involve multiple institutions, regional offices, officials, committees, deadlines and supporting documents. Coordinating them creates operational challenges: applications may remain pending, deadlines may be missed, documents may approach expiry without timely renewal, and officials may need to spend considerable time following up on outstanding actions.

Problem Statement 26262 proposes an integrated digital platform that automates routine approval-related workflows, monitors institutional compliance, tracks deadlines and generates notifications and escalations for pending or overdue actions.

The platform is intended to improve administrative efficiency, transparency and accountability while preserving human oversight. Automated workflow actions, reminders and recommendations must support—not replace—statutory scrutiny, verification, inspections and decisions reserved for competent authorities.

In simple terms, the objective is to help AICTE and institutions know what action is required, who is responsible, when it is due and whether it has been completed.

2. Background and Context

2.1 What is AICTE?

AICTE stands for the All India Council for Technical Education. It is a statutory body associated with the regulation and planned development of technical education in India, within its applicable legal and regulatory mandate. Technical institutions may be required to obtain approval for specified activities, programmes or institutional changes under applicable regulations.

The approval process can involve applications, supporting documents, regulatory scrutiny, inspections where prescribed, committee reviews and decisions by authorised authorities.

2.2 What is the Approval Process Handbook?

The Approval Process Handbook (APH) establishes applicable procedures, requirements and timelines for approval-related activities. Different applications may follow different routes: some may require scrutiny alone, while others may require scrutiny followed by an EVC or additional committee-level processing.

Consequently, the software cannot assume that every application follows an identical sequence. It must support configurable workflows that reflect the applicable requirements.

2.3 What is institutional compliance?

Institutional compliance refers to fulfilling requirements, conditions or undertakings imposed under the applicable approval framework. Some requirements may need to be fulfilled during the application process; others may remain applicable after approval has been granted.

For example, an institution might be required to submit specified evidence by a particular date or provide a renewed document when required. The system must therefore monitor both the progress of applications and obligations that continue after approval.

3. The Core Problem

The central problem is the coordination and monitoring of a large number of interconnected approval and compliance activities. An application may pass through several stages, require clarification, wait for inspection scheduling or need further verification. At the same time, an institution may have outstanding undertakings or documents approaching expiry.

Each activity has its own status, responsible party, supporting evidence and potentially applicable deadline. Without reliable coordination and monitoring, several operational risks arise:

1. Applications may remain pending because the next administrative action has not been initiated promptly.
2. Officials may have difficulty identifying the oldest pending cases and the reasons for delays.
3. EVC scheduling and completion may require repeated manual follow-up.
4. Institutions may miss compliance deadlines or fail to submit prescribed evidence on time.
5. Lease documents and other prescribed documents may expire without timely renewal.
6. Regional and central authorities may lack a consolidated view of pending work and emerging bottlenecks.
7. Incomplete records of notifications, submissions, verification and decisions may make accountability more difficult.

The problem statement seeks to address these risks through an integrated platform with workflow automation, centralised monitoring, automated alerts, escalation mechanisms and a complete digital audit trail.

The problem statement identifies operational challenges that the proposed solution should address. It does not establish that every identified issue occurs in every existing AICTE workflow.

4. Understanding the Approval Workflow

4.1 What is a workflow?

A workflow is a defined sequence of activities through which an application or case progresses. A simplified example is: Application submitted → Scrutiny → Additional prescribed processing → Authorised review → Decision or another prescribed outcome. The actual stages and their order depend on the applicable rules and the type of application.

4.2 Why is workflow automation needed?

In a manually coordinated process, officials may need to identify completed activities, determine which stage comes next, assign responsibility and communicate the next action. The proposed system should automate routine administrative steps wherever the applicable procedure permits.

For example, once an authorised official completes a scrutiny stage and all required conditions for progression are satisfied, the system should route the application to the next prescribed stage. This reduces avoidable administrative effort and helps prevent cases from being overlooked.

4.3 Different application routes

The problem statement identifies several possible workflow combinations:

- **Only Scrutiny**
- **Scrutiny + EVC**
- **EVC + SAC/SHC**
- **Only EVC**
- Other combinations prescribed under the applicable APH.

The software must represent different routes instead of forcing every application through a single fixed sequence.

4.4 Returning applications for deficiencies

An application may contain incomplete information, missing documents or issues requiring clarification. The system must allow authorised officials to return or revert an application for a legitimate reason. The return should record the reason, relevant observations, responsible party and subsequent actions. When the institution responds, the application should return to the appropriate stage according to configured rules.

Automation must not bypass any scrutiny or verification required by the applicable procedure.

5. Detailed Analysis of Required Functional Areas

5.1 End-to-End Approval Workflow Automation

Objective: Manage the movement of applications through their prescribed processing stages.

The system should:

- Route applications according to configurable workflow rules.
- Support different combinations of scrutiny, EVC, SAC/SHC and other applicable stages.
- Move applications forward when required preceding activities are complete and progression conditions are satisfied.
- Allow authorised returns or reversions for deficiencies, clarification or further verification.
- Record reasons for returns and relevant observations.
- Automate routine administrative communications and case summaries where permitted.
- Maintain a record of application movement and actions performed at each stage.

Expected benefit: Reduced manual coordination, more consistent processing and improved visibility into the current status of each application.

5.2 Integrated Dashboard and Pendency Monitoring

Objective: Provide a consolidated view of application processing and administrative workload.

The dashboard should display information such as:

- Total applications received and their current status.
- Applications pending at each processing stage.
- Application ageing and applicable processing timelines.
- Cases approaching or exceeding prescribed timelines.
- Workload distribution across regions, officials and committees.
- Applications awaiting action from a specific institution or official.
- Processing bottlenecks and unresolved deficiencies.

Different users should see dashboards appropriate to their roles and permissions. A regional officer may need visibility into regional pendency, whereas a bureau officer may need a broader view across multiple regions.

The system should distinguish elapsed time from the applicable prescribed processing timeline and represent the reason for a delay where that information is available.

Expected benefit: Better workload management, quicker identification of bottlenecks and improved accountability.

5.3 EVC Scheduling and Alerts

Objective: Monitor applications requiring an Expert Visit Committee and track their scheduling and completion.

An EVC is an Expert Visit Committee involved in an inspection or evaluation process where prescribed. The system should:

- Identify applications for which an EVC is required.
- Place eligible applications into the appropriate scheduling queue after preliminary processing is complete.
- Record relevant scheduling and completion information.
- Track applicable timelines, particularly for new institutions where specified.
- Generate reminders for approaching deadlines.
- Flag delayed or overdue cases.
- Escalate delays to designated authorities according to authorised rules.

The system is responsible for tracking and facilitating the process. It must not replace the inspection, expert assessment or regulatory decision itself.

Expected benefit: Improved scheduling visibility, reduced missed follow-ups and better monitoring of EVC-related delays.

5.4 Time-Bound Undertakings and Institutional Compliance

Objective: Track conditions and undertakings that institutions must fulfil within prescribed timelines.

An undertaking is a commitment or declaration made by an institution in the context of applicable regulatory requirements. Where an undertaking imposes a time-bound obligation, its fulfilment must be monitored.

The system should maintain records of:

- The institution and the approval or case associated with the obligation.
- The prescribed condition or undertaking.
- The applicable due date.
- Required supporting documents or evidence.
- Submission status and submission date.
- Verification status and observations from authorised officials.
- Outstanding or overdue obligations.

Institutions should be able to submit supporting evidence electronically. The system should notify institutions of upcoming deadlines, track submissions and alert officials when obligations remain unfulfilled.

It should distinguish between an obligation that has not been submitted, one that has been submitted but awaits verification, and one that has been verified and closed.

Expected benefit: More reliable monitoring of institutional obligations and fewer missed compliance deadlines.

5.5 Lease and Document Validity Monitoring

Objective: Track the validity and renewal of lease documents and other prescribed documents wherever applicable.

Some documents have an expiry date or require renewal under applicable requirements. The system should maintain relevant metadata, including:

- Document type and associated institution.
- Related application, approval or compliance obligation.
- Issue date, validity period and expiry date, where applicable.
- Document submission and verification status.

- Renewal requirements and the status of any replacement document.

The system should generate configurable advance reminders, notify institutions when renewal action is required, track renewed-document submissions and alert officials about expired documents or overdue renewals.

A renewed document should not automatically be treated as valid or compliant merely because it has been uploaded. Where verification is required, an authorised official must review it and record the outcome.

Expected benefit: Better document lifecycle management, fewer overlooked expiry dates and improved visibility into outstanding renewal requirements.

5.6 Automated Notifications, Escalation and Reporting

Objective: Ensure that pending, upcoming and overdue actions receive appropriate attention.

The system should support notifications for applications awaiting action, applications approaching prescribed timelines, EVC scheduling and completion deadlines, upcoming compliance obligations, pending supporting-document submissions, documents approaching expiry, and overdue cases or unresolved deficiencies.

Notification rules should be configurable according to applicable procedures and authorised administrative requirements. An escalation mechanism should identify unresolved overdue cases and notify the designated authority when escalation criteria are met.

The system should record relevant events, notification recipients, timestamps, escalation history and eventual closure. It should also generate reports covering application pendency, EVC status, compliance obligations, document validity, overdue cases and regional processing performance.

Expected benefit: Less repetitive manual follow-up, more timely intervention and stronger administrative accountability.

6. Key Stakeholders and Their Responsibilities

6.1 Technical Institutions

- Submit applications and supporting documents.
- Respond to deficiencies or clarification requests.
- Track application status.
- Receive notifications about deadlines and outstanding actions.
- Submit evidence for undertakings and compliance requirements.
- Upload renewed documents where required.
- Track the verification status of submissions.

6.2 Regional Officers

Regional officers may need to monitor applications assigned to their region, review pending work and approaching deadlines, track responsible officials and unresolved cases, receive delay alerts, and take authorised actions while recording observations.

6.3 Bureau Officers

Bureau-level users may require a consolidated view of processing across regions, including workload, ageing, bottlenecks and overdue matters. Their access and authority must reflect their actual administrative responsibilities.

6.4 Committees and Authorised Officials

Relevant committees and officials need access to assigned cases, supporting records and required actions. They must be able to record observations and outcomes according to their permissions.

6.5 System Administrators and Rule Managers

Authorised administrators may manage user access, role assignments, notification settings and approved workflow configurations. Changes to regulatory rules or prescribed timelines should be controlled, versioned and auditable rather than editable without restriction.

7. Cross-Cutting System Requirements

7.1 Configurability

Workflow stages, applicable timelines, reminder intervals and escalation rules must be configurable to reflect the relevant APH and other applicable regulations.

7.2 Role-Based Access Control

Users should only be able to view or modify information and perform actions authorised for their roles. An institution should not be able to alter an official's verification record, and an unauthorised user should not be able to approve or reassign a case.

7.3 Secure Document Storage

Institutional applications and supporting documents may contain confidential information. The system must protect stored documents and control access to them. Appropriate controls may include secure authentication, authorised document access, encryption, access logging and protected backups.

7.4 Digital Audit Trail

The system must maintain traceable records of application movement, observations, submissions, verification, notifications, escalations and closure. An audit record should capture relevant information such as the action performed, the user or system process responsible, the timestamp and the outcome.

7.5 Integration with Existing Systems

The problem statement calls for integration with existing authorised AICTE systems wherever feasible. Any integration would depend on approved interfaces, access permissions, technical compatibility and applicable data-governance requirements. A prototype may demonstrate intended integration through simulated data or mock interfaces, but it must not claim a live integration that has not been implemented.

7.6 Human Oversight

The platform must preserve the role of competent authorities in regulatory scrutiny, verification, inspections and decisions. Automated routing and alerts should help officials perform their duties more efficiently without assuming powers that belong to authorised decision-makers.

8. Expected Outcomes

Outcome	Intended improvement
Reduced manual effort	Less repetitive administrative work and fewer manual reminders.
More efficient processing	Applications move through prescribed stages with better coordination.
Improved transparency	Users can see application status, outstanding actions and relevant timelines.
Better EVC monitoring	Scheduling and completion delays become easier to identify.
Improved compliance	Institutions receive timely reminders about undertakings and required submissions.
Reduced document-expiry risk	Renewal requirements can be identified before expiry.
Stronger accountability	Audit trails provide a reliable history of actions and outcomes.
Better resource utilisation	Administrators can identify workload imbalances and processing bottlenecks.
More consistent administration	Configurable rules help ensure cases are handled according to their applicable workflows.

These are intended outcomes. Their actual achievement would need to be assessed through measurable performance indicators and testing.

9. Prototype and Evaluation Criteria

The problem statement expects a working prototype demonstrating the core capabilities rather than merely a conceptual proposal. The prototype should demonstrate:

- Automated routing between configured application stages.
- Role-based dashboards and access restrictions.
- Stage-wise pendency and application-ageing monitoring.
- EVC queue management and deadline alerts.
- Undertaking records and compliance submission tracking.
- Lease and document expiry monitoring.
- Notifications for upcoming and overdue actions.
- Escalation of unresolved overdue cases.
- A complete, traceable digital audit trail.

Evaluation may consider workflow accuracy, alert timeliness, reliability of deadline tracking, visibility of pending cases, reduction in manual follow-up and completeness of audit records.

A credible demonstration should use realistic test scenarios, including an application that advances normally, an application returned for deficiencies, a compliance deadline approaching, a document requiring renewal and an overdue case that triggers escalation. Synthetic data can be used when real institutional data is unavailable.

10. Regulatory Safeguards and System Limitations

The system must operate in accordance with applicable AICTE regulations, the Approval Process Handbook and authorised administrative procedures.

- An automated transition must not bypass a required scrutiny or verification stage.
- A reminder must not be treated as proof that an institution has fulfilled an obligation.
- Uploading a document must not be treated as verification or acceptance.
- An overdue alert must not automatically imply a regulatory violation or adverse decision without the prescribed assessment.
- Automated recommendations must not replace inspections or decisions reserved for competent authorities.
- Workflow configurations and timeline changes must be controlled and traceable.
- User permissions must prevent unauthorised changes to applications, evidence and official records.

The system's purpose is to support regulatory administration, improve visibility and reduce avoidable delays—not to automate statutory decision-making beyond what is expressly permitted.

11. Scope of the Proposed Solution

The project should be understood as an integrated approval and compliance management platform with six interconnected capabilities:

1. Approval workflow automation.
2. Dashboard and pendency monitoring.
3. EVC scheduling and tracking.
4. Institutional undertaking and compliance management.
5. Lease and prescribed-document validity monitoring.
6. Notifications, escalation, reporting and audit trails.

These capabilities should operate on shared records so that information about an application, its associated institution, its obligations and its pending actions remains consistent.

The project is broader than a conventional application-tracking portal because it covers both the application lifecycle and continuing compliance obligations. It is also broader than a reminder application because it includes configurable workflow routing, role-based access, administrative reporting, document verification tracking and traceable records.

12. Conclusion

Problem Statement 26262 addresses the challenge of coordinating approval-related workflows and institutional compliance activities across AICTE's administrative environment.

The central requirement is a unified platform that makes application movement, responsibility, deadlines, compliance status and unresolved actions visible and actionable.

A successful solution must combine configurable workflow automation, reliable deadline tracking, role-specific dashboards, EVC management, institutional compliance monitoring, document renewal tracking, automated notifications, escalation and a comprehensive audit trail.

Above all, the system must balance automation with regulatory safeguards. Routine administrative activities should be automated wherever permitted, while scrutiny, verification, inspections and statutory decisions remain with the appropriate competent authorities.

The fundamental objective is to ensure that the right application or compliance case reaches the right person, the required action is tracked against the applicable timeline, and unresolved matters receive timely attention—with a reliable record of what happened throughout the process.

Appendix: Essential Terms

Term	Meaning in this problem statement
AICTE	All India Council for Technical Education.
APH	Approval Process Handbook; the applicable procedural and regulatory guidance for approval-related activities.
EVC	Expert Visit Committee; involved in an inspection or evaluation process where prescribed.
SAC/SHC	Committee-stage terminology referenced in the problem statement; exact roles and applicability must be validated against the relevant procedure.
Pendency	Work or applications that remain incomplete or awaiting an action.
Undertaking	A commitment or declaration that may impose a requirement to be fulfilled by an institution.
Compliance evidence	Documents or other prescribed supporting material submitted to demonstrate fulfilment of a requirement.
Escalation	Routing an unresolved or overdue matter to a designated authority under configured rules.
Audit trail	A traceable record of actions, users or processes, timestamps and outcomes.

Document note: This is an explanatory analysis of the supplied problem statement, not a substitute for the current AICTE regulations, the applicable APH, or official administrative instructions.